somewhat obliquely across the abdomen. It has two orifices: the one just alluded to, namely, the cardiac orifice, by which the food is received, and the other at its smaller extremity, called the pyloric orifice, the office of which is to convey the semi-digested food from the stomach into the intestines. Both these orifices are surrounded with muscular bands, which close upon the interior sac, and only open or expand when it is essential to receive or to expel the food from the cavity of the stomach.

The stomach has three coats, consisting of an external covering, or serous membrane; a muscular or middle coating, formed of highly elastic muscular fibre, the property of which is to contract and expand, and thus promote the rolling motion occurring whilst the food is being digested in the stomach; and an inner lining, called, as before stated, the mucous membrane, the office of which is not only to cover the interior surface with a smooth slimy fluid, but also to contain the countless number of little follicles or glands through which the gastric juices are poured out and secreted; in fact, the surface of the mucous membrane or inner lining of the stomach is pierced with little glands and processes so thickly set that millions of them may be counted under the microscope. When this organ contains no food these glands are at rest, but directly food is introduced into the cardiac orifice, the follicles pour out an acrid fluid secreted within them, which, running down into the contents of the stomach, so dissolves and changes them that all matters susceptible of digestion become converted into a pulpy mass called chyme.